

LESSON 4 QUICK REFERENCE CARD

Core Concept Validation: The Three-Gate System

THE VALIDATION SEQUENCE

YOUR CORE CONCEPT FROM LESSON 3

Example: "Your ads aren't broken. Your position is unspoken."



GATE 1: SCORECARD

🕒 20 min | 📊 12 categories weighted to 100

INPUTS NEEDED:

- Core Concept articulation
- USP statement
- Unique methodology (2–3 sentences)
- Top competitor types
- Failed solutions prospects tried

THRESHOLDS:

- ✅ 85–100 = PASS → Proceed to Gate 2
- ⚠️ 80–84 = CHECK Category 4 (USP Connection)
 - If Cat 4 $\geq 10/12$ → Proceed
 - If Cat 4 $< 10/12$ → Refine CC first
- ❌ <80 = REFINE → Back to Lesson 3 articulation tools

YOUR SCORE: ____ / 100

CATEGORY 4: ____ / 12 (highest weight – critical!)



GATE 2: EVIDENCE EXCAVATION ⚠️ THE GATEKEEPING TEST

🕒 30 min | 📊 10 evidence categories

INPUTS NEEDED:

- Core Concept articulation

- UNDERLYING PRINCIPLE (not just catchy phrase)
Example: "Positioning before tactics" = principle
- Market context (who is this for?)
- Current belief → New belief

THRESHOLDS:

- ✅ 80+ pieces across multiple categories = PASS
→ Proceed to Gate 3
- ⚠️ 50–80 pieces with gaps = DISCUSS
→ Schedule 1-on-1 with Rich
- ❌ <50 pieces = WRONG CC
→ STOP. Return to Lesson 3. Find provable principle.

YOUR EVIDENCE COUNT: _____ pieces

A-TIER COUNT: _____ pieces (need 15–20 minimum)

CONFIDENCE: _____% (need 85%+ for strong validation)

✂️ CRITICAL: This gate is ABSOLUTE. No evidence = wrong CC.
Better to fail here than after building belief chain.



GATE 3: VALIDATION ENGINE

🕒 15 min | 💡 Emotional resonance test

INPUTS NEEDED:

- Core Concept (now proven via Gate 2)
- Failed solution inventory
- Market sophistication level

THRESHOLDS:

- ✅ 70–100 = PASS → Proceed to Lesson 5
- ⚠️ 60–69 = REFINEMENT OPPORTUNITY (not blocking)
- ❌ <60 = WEAK emotional resonance (consider broader CC)

YOUR SCORE: _____ / 100

COVERAGE: _____% of failures explained

NOTE: This is optimization, not gatekeeping. Evidence
Excavation was THE gate. This refines emotional impact.



✅ READY FOR LESSON 5
(Build Belief Chain with Confidence)

QUICK DECISION MATRIX

GATE 1	GATE 2	GATE 3	VERDICT
✓ 85+	✓ 80+	✓ 70+	PROCEED to Lesson 5
✓ 85+	✓ 80+	⚠ 60-69	PROCEED (note refinements)
✓ 85+	✗ <50	any	STOP - Wrong CC
⚠ 80-84	any	any	CHECK Cat 4 first
✗ <80	any	any	REFINE - Don't test Gate 2 yet

CRITICAL RULES

GATE 2 IS ABSOLUTE

- **Can't negotiate on evidence.** <50 pieces = wrong CC.
- **Don't proceed without 80+ strong pieces.** You'll waste 40+ hours building belief chain to unprovable assertion.
- **"My CC is unique" is not an excuse.** The PRINCIPLE underneath must have evidence.

CATEGORY 4 IS MAKE-OR-BREAK

- **USP Connection (12% weight) is highest for a reason.**
- **If < 10/12:** Your CC drives category demand, not YOUR demand.
- **Test:** "If they believe my CC, MUST they logically need MY solution?"

ARTICULATION VS PRINCIPLE

- **Your articulation can be new:** "Your ads aren't broken. Your position is unspoken."
- **Your principle is never new:** "Positioning before tactics" (56 years evidence)
- **Evidence Excavation tests the PRINCIPLE, not the catchy phrase.**

THE 10 EVIDENCE CATEGORIES

Quick checklist - you need strong evidence across MULTIPLE categories:

1. ☐ **Academic Foundation** - Peer-reviewed research, university studies
2. ☐ **Expert Validation** - Recognized authorities unanimous

3. ☐ **Empirical Evidence** - Statistical studies, quantified impacts
4. ☐ **Business Case Studies** - Documented transformations with metrics
5. ☐ **Historical Precedents** - 50+ year patterns, landmark campaigns
6. ☐ **Contrary Evidence** - Objections addressed, counter-examples explained
7. ☐ **Analogies & Parallels** - Cross-domain validation
8. ☐ **Market-Specific Applications** - Your industry examples
9. ☐ **Quotable Authority** - Memorable expert quotes
10. ☐ **Demonstrative Proof** - "Try this now" mechanisms

If you have gaps in 3+ categories: Weak validation. Dig deeper or reconsider CC.

DOCUMENTS TO HAVE READY

Before Starting Validation:

- ☐ Your 12+ Core Concept articulations (Lesson 3)
 - ☐ USP statement (Lesson 2)
 - ☐ Unique methodology description
 - ☐ Failed solution inventory (Avatar Excavation)
 - ☐ Competitor landscape map
 - ☐ Your CC's underlying PRINCIPLE (not just catchy articulation)
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TIME ALLOCATION

- **Gate 1 (Scorecard):** 20 minutes
- **Gate 2 (Evidence Excavation):** 30 minutes ← **PROTECT THIS TIME**
- **Gate 3 (Validation Engine):** 15 minutes
- **Decision & Next Steps:** 5 minutes

Total: 70 minutes for complete validation

RED FLAGS

STOP immediately if:

-  Evidence Excavation finds <50 pieces
-  Most evidence is C-Tier (tangential, weak sources)
-  Category 4 (USP Connection) scores <8/12
-  You're rationalizing: "But my CC is different/new/unique"

These mean wrong Core Concept. Return to Lesson 3.

GREEN LIGHTS

Proceed confidently if:

-  Scorecard 85+ with Category 4 at 10+/12
-  Evidence 80+ pieces with 15+ A-Tier across 7+ categories
-  Validation 70+ explaining most failures
-  All three reports saved and organized

You now have a validated, provable Core Concept ready for belief chain building.

REMEMBER

"It's not just the idea. It's the articulation of the idea." — Mark Ford

"And it's the PROOF of the idea." — Rich Schefren

Without overwhelming proof, even million-dollar articulation is worthless.

WHEN TO GET HELP

Schedule 1-on-1 with Rich if:

- Evidence Excavation found 50-80 pieces (borderline)
- Category 4 scored 8-9/12 (close but not tight)
- All three scores are "yellow" (need strategic guidance)
- You're unsure if your principle is provable

Don't proceed alone if uncertain. This is foundation of everything.

YOUR SCORES

Fill this out as you go:

GATE 1: SCORECARD

Total Score: _____ / 100

Category 4 (USP): _____ / 12

Decision: ☐ Proceed ☐ Refine ☐ Stop

GATE 2: EVIDENCE EXCAVATION

Evidence Pieces: _____ total

A-Tier Pieces: _____

Validation Confidence: _____%

Decision: ☐ Proceed ☐ Discuss ☐ Wrong CC

GATE 3: VALIDATION ENGINE

Validation Score: _____ / 100

Coverage: _____% of failures explained

Decision: ☐ Proceed ☐ Refine ☐ Reconsider

FINAL VERDICT:

- ☐ PROCEED to Lesson 5
- ☐ REFINE (specify what): _____
- ☐ RETURN to Lesson 3 (new CC needed)

Next Step: If proceeding, save all three reports and bring to Lesson 5.

Key Files:

1. Scorecard Report (12 categories)
2. Evidence Excavation Report (80+ pieces organized)
3. Validation Engine Report (failure reframes)

These become your content engine for the next 12 months.

Print this card and keep it next to you during validation.